

English Translation: Mona, Andres. "La guerre de la marmite." *Petites Chroniques éclatées : Nouvelles Littéraires*, Mordus des mots, Éditions David (2017): 25-30. Short story.

The Kettle War

It was the 6th of October 1784. I, Captain Lieven van Isseghem, of Ostend, had been charged with a vital task by His Imperial Highness, the Holy Roman Emperor. We were to immediately embark up the river Scheldt, ignoring all Dutch vessels, lest we be attacked. Our proud ship, *The Louis*, left the port that same day, accompanied by two other vessels. The ship's crew was not of considerable size but were well experienced. The members of which I respected the most were my second in command, the Lieutenant-Captain Augustine de Launoy, a young man with a remarkable skill for war, the Quartermaster Vincent Wegmann, the oldest, meanest, and most stubborn of the lot and the Chaplain Germund Vahlen, a well-educated man of noble descendance. And though a man of God, he was a great sinner due to his arrogance and the terrible proudness of his character. Finally, was the cook Gustav Schrempf, of weak stature and physique but of fierce character; he was a good friend, though not a very good cook. With these reliable men and the rest of the crew, our small party made its way to Antwerp.

That same day, I came out to the deck, to examine the boat and the crew. The men worked hard as per usual. The sailors walked along the deck and completed various tasks and errands. At the bow of the ship stood Lieutenant de Launoy and Father Vahlen, with a small contingent of soldiers. The lieutenant was the first to notice me and subsequently bowed his head in my direction. I headed towards him and the group. To my left, I could distinguish one of the ships that was accompanying us. It was a much smaller vessel, a merchant ship, barely armored and with practically no offensive capabilities. The lieutenant and the chaplain had also already begun to walk towards me. The lieutenant was the first to speak.

-Good day, Captain.

-Everything is in order, I hope.

-Sir, yes of course! Both the boat and the crew are ready! said de Launoy with a certain youthful pride.

-You very much prove your value, Mr. de Launoy. I hope you will persist in your professional diligence.

We walked along the length of the ship, observing the crew and the landscape as we sailed by. It was the beginning of the afternoon, it was pretty, there was little wind and no rain. The Flemish countryside passed before us; mostly flat, agricultural lands they appeared to be. When we arrived at the rear of the ship, the lieutenant looked at me directly and said:

-Sir, I have held my tongue for some time now, but my Captain, I must know what exactly we have been tasked with.

-I was not given many details. I was merely ordered to immediately escort these two merchant ships on the Scheldt.

The lieutenant paused for a moment before carrying on:

-This mission seems rather dubious. We are entering Dutch waters, they will certainly view our actions as an aggressive incursion.

-I would not be worried, Lieutenant, I told him, attempting to reassure him. The Dutch can be and have been quite stubborn, but they are not utterly stupid. I would not think they would risk war with us.

The Lieutenant now looked worried.

-I would put little confidence in the Dutch for anything. They are as cruel as they are unforgiving.

-You may be correct Mr. de Launoy.

I looked into the distance, towards the horizon and then ordered the men to assemble, as we were nearly arriving at Antwerp.

Later that night, the cook Gustav entered my quarters with one of my favorite dishes. He wished me a pleasant meal and left me to my own thoughts and devices. It was one of the few even rare moments where I could ease up. I had just lit my pipe when came knocking from the door.

-Captain, we are arriving at Antwerp.

On the deck, the entire crew stood ready, soldiers flanked either side of the ships. Beside the main mast was located the Lieutenant, the Chaplain, and the Quartermaster Wegmann. I paced towards them and greeted all three men.

-Report, Lieutenant!

-We are approaching what appears to be a defended position in close proximity to Antwerp.

In the distance, it was clear that the fort had spotted the small flotilla. The Dutch had begun to send off signals in order to identify our vessels. But as the three ships passed the fort, the silence was deafening. And only a few moments later, the flotilla carried on to Antwerp without harassment or issue from the fort. Strange, I thought. However, the crew seemed relieved, the Chaplain was remarkably pale, but both the Lieutenant and the Quartermaster appeared more or less content with the outcome of the situation.

-I will retire now for the night. You have command of the ship.

-Yes Sir. Answered the young Lieutenant.

In my room that night, I suffered a most horrible dream. I was standing on what seemed to be the deck of my ship. The fog was thick and nothing could be seen. In my dream, I felt the greatest dread, but to what or who I could not say. Suddenly, I heard the crack of an explosion, and I felt such an intense heat, as if I were burning. The explosion had swept aside the fog, and where it had occurred stood a blackened and masked figure. I was compelled to walk forwards, towards the shadow figure. As I did, it began to scream. Its screams were deafening, painful and miserable, like the cries of a mother who has lost their child. The creature wretched and cried louder with the passing of each moment. It was then that I woke up. I woke up with a startle, sweating profusely and still with that horrible feeling of dread. The dream had to be an omen of an event or thing to come maybe a disaster, or a death or a battle.

The morning passed and that afternoon, I knocked on the door of the priest.

-Ah, Mr. Van Isseghem, what a surprise! He exclaimed.

-Good day Mr. Vahlen, I must speak with you... about a personal matter.

It was a small room, with a bed, a desk and a single chair.

-Please, sit. Tell me, what is this personal matter you'd wish to discuss?

I told the Chaplain about my dream and about everything I saw, everything I felt and I everything I heard. When I finished speaking, the priest was silent for some time. When he finally began to speak, it was evident that he was perplexed.

-Truly, I am sorry... I have no idea what your dream could signify. I would not worry Captain, do not put much faith in dreams or in supposed omens.

I left his chambers, after these words and continued my command of the voyage, trying not to think upon my dream. The convoy had made significant progress up the Scheldt. Later that day, I retired to my quarters as was my custom and awaited Gustav for my supper. Gustav was on time,

as was custom, and I enjoyed my meal and the remainder of the evening without interruption. During the night, I relived the same dream. Before me, stood the shadowy figure, however, this time I could discern an object in its hands. The object in the creatures' hands appeared to be made from metal and it was rounded but I could not make out fully what it was. I woke up suddenly and was quick to notice Lieutenant de Launoy standing before me.

-Captain! It is urgent.

I dressed myself quickly and made my way to the deck. The day was exceedingly foggy, but I could perceive the silhouette of a very large ship, not far ahead of where we were. The lieutenant, the chaplain, the quartermaster and the cook all stood with me. The priest prayed vigorously, the cook held a large kettle he had brought from the kitchen, the quartermaster appeared unbothered and the lieutenant maintained his bearings. The lieutenant then indicated the presence of the other ship.

-A Dutch frigate. She intercepted us and has just fired a warning shot. We await your orders, Captain.

I analyzed the situation:

-We will protect the other two boats at all costs, stand fast. We may be smaller, but we are far faster.

The crew agreed and ran off to fulfill their Captain's orders. For a moment, the fog and the mist appeared to thicken before a massive explosion ripped across the water. I threw myself down on the deck, a projectile had flown past me. Some moments passed and I stood up. It was then that I heard those miserable cries. Near the ship's mast was gathered the majority of the crew, all looking at something on the deck. I knew that the screams originated from that spot. I could see the priest and the lieutenant, standing, their faces flush with anger and disgust. I push passed

crowd to see what was happening. There, in the middle of the mass of people, was the cook Gustav. Before the cook was a metal object turned over and a yellow liquid that surrounded him.

The cook was crying and screaming like a madman.

-Those bastards! Let them go to hell!

-Mr. Gustav Schrempf, what on Earth are you doing!?!?

He ignored me and continued.

-My kettle... my soup... oh my soup.

I stood there silently. With no words to spare. The warning shot from the Dutch ship had struck Gustav's kettle, spilling all the soup he had prepared and marking the sole casualty of the day.